

Weekly Writing - Week 1

Laila Ismail

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1. Thoughts on Generative AI in the Classroom

When posed with the question of whether I would want to learn with generative AI doing all the coding and thus focus more on content and concepts or learning through trial, tears, and error by actual coding, I would personally choose the latter. A class where you are actually learning the mechanisms behind how each part of a code works is more attractive to me because it requires a fundamental understanding of concepts. This line of reasoning is similar to the idea that social science approaches to statistical learning differ from that of non-social science approaches by answering the question of why. For example, if we are to look at a graph that AI coded, one will learn information from the graph. However, if we are asked how the code computed the graph, we would not be able to answer it without the knowledge one gains from doing actual coding. Currently, I think that students are becoming over reliant on generative AI, and are using AI as a replacement rather than a tool for completing tasks. While it certainly is a helpful tool, the sole use of AI replaces the real learning that occurs through the trials and errors of actual coding. I personally think that an individual learns and understands a concept better by grappling with a task. Additionally, with using AI for coding, there is much time spent having to redirect AI as it is not always accurate. The time spent redirecting AI to compute all the code necessary for the course, in my opinion, would be best spent interactively engaging with the concepts and writing out the code. Spending 30 percent of the class figuring out the coding concepts while still covering content provides a perfect balance between content and acquiring skills in coding. On the other hand, if AI were to do all the coding and the class was more focused on concepts, there would be a lack of understanding behind how the coding language works. In conclusion, while a world where ChatGPT does all the coding would allow for more time to cover difficult concepts, I would prefer to learn by doing the coding myself.